my view, they could just as well be interpreted to symbolize the ‘Chakravartin’ or Universal Monarch. The pillars and the lions are a clear expression of imperial power. They were the Mauryan way of marking territory.

Remember that Ashoka’s average subject would have been illiterate and would have been unable to read the noble sentiments in the inscription. He/she, however, would have been left in no doubt about the real message regarding the power of the sovereign. The use of columns to signal imperial might is not unique to the Mauryans or even to India. The ancient Egyptians and the Romans used them as well. In India, the imperial successors of the Mauryas would raise their own columns as well as insert their own inscriptions on the Ashokan columns.

The Mauryan lions and pillars were mostly made from sandstone quarried at Chunar, near Varanasi, where the Ganga nudges the Vindhya range. We now know the exact location of the quarries to the south-west of Chunar fort, close to the famous Durga temple. Stone is still quarried here, and one can also see some of the ancient quarries as well as cylindrical blocks of unfinished stone abandoned by the ancient stone-cutters. Some of them bear inscriptions that identify the era when the stone was originally quarried.

It appears that the Mauryans rolled the stones to the river and then transported them by boat to workshops near Varanasi, in much the same manner as the ancient Egyptians transported stone blocks down the Nile to construct their temples and pyramids. Although various irrigation projects these days have drastically reduced the water-flow in the Ganga, it is still possible to make the journey by boat from Chunar to Varanasi. Archaeologists have found remains of workshops along the river where this stone was carved and polished. [25] As the river turns, the ancient ghats of Varanasi come into sight and, for a moment, one can imagine oneself as a Mauryan boatman transporting Chunar stone to the imperial workshop.

The stone used to carve the Sarnath lions, modern India’s national symbol, would have made this journey from quarry to workshop and then to Sarnath. I found several stone-carvers who still work the Chunar sandstone